

« Each coach has taught me something important for a lifetime »

SELVAM KARTHI

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During the recent Asian Champions Trophy (ACT) tournament in Chennai, up-and-coming hockey players, along with a few senior citizens and kids, flocked to the Mayor Radhakrishnan Stadium in Egmore to witness the performance of their home state player, Selvam Karthi.

The 22-year-old from Ariyalur, Tamil Nadu, didn't let down his fans, displaying flashes of shooting brilliance in several matches and contributing to India's gold medal in the tournament, which is considered a crucial practice event leading up to the Asian Games.

Before the ACT, Karthi showcased his striking skills in various games of the Pro League held in Rourkela, London, and the Netherlands, earning praise from both critics and fans.

While there were expectations that he might be selected for the Indian men's squad at the Hangzhou Asian Games, the selectors opted for senior players, leaving Karthi disappointed. Undeterred, he has

been working on improving his game based on feedback from coaches and well-wishers.

Now, his sights are set on the 2024 Paris Olympics. In an interview with *Sportstar*, he acknowledged the tough competition from senior players in his position. "I have to work harder to be part of the team for Paris," he said, while training with the Tamil Nadu men's team in Chennai for the Goa National Games.

Describe your journey from Ariyalur to the senior national team.

It has been a fantastic learning experience so far. I've interacted with a number of coaches and had the opportunity to play alongside individuals with varying playing styles from different states. Actually, when I joined the junior team at the camp in 2021, I trained a lot in Bengaluru, but I didn't get a chance to be a part of the junior set-up as I was not in the Indian team for the 2021 Junior World Cup in Bhubaneswar. I didn't worry about it too much. Soon, I made my debut in the men's Asia

Cup in Dhaka. Then I played in the Pro League and the ACT in Chennai. I couldn't have asked for more. At the same time, there is still plenty to learn and adapt to.

You are a product of the hostels of the Sports Development Authority of Tamil Nadu, where you stayed at a young age while actively participating in tournaments. How was the experience?

I have been in sports hostels since my seventh-grade year at the YMCA College in Chennai. My journey led me to Tiruchi and later to Kovilpatti as I continued studying in sports hostels. A number of coaches, including Raja, Santhosh, R. Siva, and N. Muthukumar, shaped my game. It was coach Siva sir in Tiruchi who insisted that I switch my position from a center half to a forward/striker.

During inter-sports hostel tournaments in Tiruchi, I formed a strong partnership with Nanda, boosting my confidence as a striker. Subsequently, at the Sports Hostel of Excellence in Kovilpatti, I developed